as the Bhawānigarh Mohendra and Noākhāli *khāls* are all used for navigation, and between them afford some 430 miles of waterway.

Steamers run daily from the Noākhāli *khāl* to Hātiā and Sandwīp, completing the round in 12 to 18 hours according to the tide. For this service the India General Railway and Steam Navigation Company receive a monthly subsidy from the District Board. Another service runs four days a week between Noākhāli and Barisāl, touching at Hātiā, and three days in the week the Barisāl-Chittagong steamers call at the islands. There is also a steamer service between Bhawāniganj and Barisāl.

Canals. But in the rains the people depend chiefly upon the numerous narrow channels, *khāl* or *donā*, for communication and transport. Of these there are a great number, some natural, some artificial. The latter mostly have not been excavated expressly for the passage of boats, but are simply the trenches from which earth has been taken to raise the roadway above flood-level.

In 1893 the District Board took charge of the inland waterways and the latest returns now show 57 channels large and small with a total length of 547 miles, including 33 miles of the Muhuri river. Of these the more important are the Begamganj-Lakhipur road side channel 22 miles long, the Mohendra *Khāl* 45 miles long from Naudona to the Meghnā (much overgrown with weeds near Naudona), the Begamganj-Seloneāh drain from Begamganj to the little Feni river and the Begamganj-Rāmganj drain 25 miles long. None of these are navigable except in the rains, and the last named can even then take only small boats, but all of them are much used.

Ferries. The ferries of the district are under the control of the District Board. There are now 46 over the principal rivers and channels and between the islands. Hātiā is served by two ferries, both starting from Lambakhāli in *thānā* Sudharām, and Sandwīp by a ferry that crosses to Siddhi from Bhānubibi. There are regular ferries connecting Chars Jabar and Jubilee with the mainland. The ferries over the big Feni are under Chittagong. The large ferries are served by *bālām* boats about 32 feet long by 7¼ feet wide and capable of taking from 60 to 80 passengers. The Tejania Nālchira ferry has two boats measuring 36 feet by 9 feet but licensed only for 40 passengers owing to the dangerous character of the crossing.

Railways. In 1896 the Assam-Bengal Railway from Chittagong to Laksām passing through Feni, the eastern sub-division of the district, was opened for traffic, and in 1903 a branch line was constructed from Laksām to Noākhāli station. This line brought the head-quarters of the district into communication with the port of Chāndpur, from which steamers run in all directions, while Feni is only 4¼ hours' run from Chittagong. Both lines are used for passenger as well as goods traffic and have been of immense assistance to the people in disposing of their surplus produce.

Rest-houses. The District Board maintains 26 inspection bungalows and rest-houses along the principal roads of the district. Most of them are temporary structures with walls of matting and wooden-doors and containing two rooms. There is also a new circuit house at Noākhāli—occupied at present as the Collector's residence—and a *dāk* bungalow maintained by the District Board. At Feni there is a P. W. D. inspection bungalow.

Conveyances. Carts are now in general use throughout the district, and as soon as a new road is opened to traffic the people living near it will buy wheels and themselves put together rude carts in which they drive their bullocks. The wheels are made of a local wood (*karai*), which serves also for stools and other articles of furniture. Ponies are rare, and pack bullocks are not used. Fish and milk are carried in vessels or baskets slung from a bamboo (*bānk*) carried on the shoulder. Other articles are usually carried on the head. Those who cannot walk travel in carts or palanquins, or on a seat (*dhuli*) slung from a bamboo carried by two men.

Boats. But in the rainy season boats afford the principal means of transport for men and merchandise.

Muhammadan boatmen use generally the *kundā*, a heavy canoe made from the trunk of a large tree, and usually covered for a considerable part of its length by two or three strips of matting bent over to form a semi-circular roof. A smaller dug-out known as a *tengi* is used in the flooded fields for going to market or reaping crops. Another common boat is the *sharanga* built of planks fastened together and flat bottomed so as to draw as little water as possible, and sometimes enlarged with side planks and roofed with bamboo matting. It is propelled with short oars or paddles fastened near the bow, or is poled in shallow waters, or towed, and may be of any size from a little skiff for a single person to a big boat carrying 100 maunds and requiring three men to manage it. In the Meghnā a longer and more slender boat known as a *gāshi* boat is found, and in the estuary an altogether larger boat known as the *bālām*. The *bālām* is built from a solid bottom with planks fastened together with cane and caulked with false hemp or straw soaked with the juice of the *gāb* tree. These boats are made in Chittagong or Sandwīp, and carry 200—300 maunds and require a crew of from five to seven men. When not required, the fastenings are undone and the planks put away carefully. They have large square sails with which they go merrily before the wind, but cannot sail near the wind, and have to be poled and paddled, a most laborious process. Occasionally *kosh* boats from Dacca may be seen, and the Chittagong boatmen come in broad sterned *sāmpāns*. The best boats are made in Chittagong or Sandwīp with *jārul* or *chaplās* wood brought from the Chittagong hills, but light dug-outs are sometimes made locally from the stem of the toddy palm.

CHAPTER IX.

OCCUPATIONS, MANUFACTURES AND TRADES.

It is to be feared that Census Table 15, showing the occupations of the people of the district, is far from accurate, but some interesting facts may be gleaned from the study of it. We find that of every ten inhabitants three are workers, and support the remaining seven. More than 79 per cent of the population depend on agriculture; excluding dependants, there are some 6,000 rent-receivers, and 225,000 rent-payers, besides 8,000 agricultural labourers, and 5,000 herdsmen. Possibly we should add to these a large proportion of the 25,000 persons described as general labourers.

Next to agriculture, fishing is the most important industry of the district. Only 222 persons have described themselves as fishermen, but there are over 7,500 sellers of fish. It is notorious that fishing is a despised occupation, and it may safely be said that many of the fish-dealers are really fishermen, and that a good many of the agriculturists are employed largely in fishing, though less than a thousand have admitted that this is their subsidiary occupation. Some 9,000 persons, of whom nearly one-fourth are women, find occupation in spinning and weaving, and of these more than 2,000 hold land. There are 1,300 potters, of whom 500 are women, over 1,000 carpenters, and less than 500 masons. Boatmen and sailors number nearly 1,000, but there are only 56 cartmen, though carts are in general use. *Pālki* bearers number over 400, and it is well known that *pālkis* are much used by women and infirm persons. There are about 2,700 priests, and over 800 medical practitioners, of whom only two are said to have diplomas. Perhaps the most curious feature of the tables is the almost entire absence of certain professions. There are no pig-breeders and swine herds, and only two persons are shown as growers of fruits and vegetables. There are but 22 boat builders, which bears out the statement that nearly all boats are imported ready made from Chittagong. The district has to support 17,000 professional mendicants.

Salt.

The production of salt from the salt impregnated lands of the islands and the southern coast was in former times a most important industry. Mr. Duncan in his report on Sandwīp states that down to the year 1728 salt was manufactured for the benefit of the *chaudhris*, and was then converted in the time of Murshīd Kuli Khān into the private monopoly of the Naib of the Subah. In 1765 the East India Company granted the monopoly of the production of salt, betel-nut and tobacco, to the Trading Company, who were to pay a duty of 35 per cent of the value of the salt produced. Three years later the monopoly was withdrawn on the

ground that the inland trade of the country should be confined to its native inhabitants. Then for a few years the manufacture was open to any one, but in 1772 it was resolved that salt should be manufactured by the Company, and that the calaries in each district should be let in farm for five years. In the five years ending in 1776 over 130,000 maunds of salt were produced annually on the lands of *pargana* Sandwīp. At that time the manufacture seems to have been in charge of Sir John Forbes, Agent at Chittagong. In 1780 the lands of Bhulua, Dakshin Shāhbāzpur, Sandwīp, Hātiā and Bāmni were constituted the Fifth Salt Division in charge of an Agent at Bhulua, and this arrangement seems to have continued for the next thirty years. In the year 1819 Mr. Walters found the average annual production of salt to be a lakh of maunds in Hātiā, rather more in Mankura, 20,000 maunds in Sandwīp, 21,000 in Bāmni, and 60,000 maunds in other islands in the Meghnā. Altogether the production was over three lakhs of maunds, and gave employment to upwards of 20,000 persons, but soon afterwards the salt lands in Bāmni were given up, and in 1826 it was recorded that they were becoming sweet. Sir William Hunter records that the manufacture was continued down to about 1862, but no correspondence on the subject of its abandonment is to be found.

Fisheries.

In the course of the year 1909 an enquiry into the fisheries of the district was made by a Sub-Deputy Collector specially deputed for the purpose, and the account which follows is based mainly on his report. Along the west and south of the district flows the Meghnā, bearing at all seasons of the year a mighty volume of water past the rivers to the sea. It has many branches winding in and out through the islands, and the mainland itself is intersected in all directions by rivers and water channels, and in the interior there are still many *bils*, or shallow lakes more or less perennial, while for three or four months of the year the greater part of the district is submerged, and the fish swarm all over the rice-fields where they spawn and hatch out their fry. And yet the fisheries are not so valuable or so prolific as in many districts farther from the sea, and the supply of fish is not nearly equal to the demand. Several causes contribute to this state of affairs. In the first place, the deep sea fisheries are practically closed to the people, as they have no boats in which they dare venture out, and even the island channels at the mouth of the Meghnā, with their treacherous tides, are avoided except by the hardiest of the fishermen. Also the want of more rapid means of communication prevents fishermen from going far from their market except in the cold weather, and fish-curing, with or without salt, is unknown. Still the fisheries are of importance and according to the census returns more than 24,000 persons depend upon fishing or the selling of fish for their livelihood, and these figures take no account of the vast number of people who at the close of the

rains, as the waters recede, catch fish for home consumption in their own fields and ditches with bamboo traps or dams and other simple contrivances. Among the fishing castes the Kaibarttas, Jele Kaibarttas as they are called to distinguish them from the Hāliā Kaibarttas or cultivators, who now prefer to call themselves Mahisya, come first in numbers and importance. Most of them have a little cultivation as well. The Namasudras also include many fishermen. The most venturesome of all the fishermen in the district are the Mālos or Jhālos, who live chiefly on the islands or on the coast of the mainland, but they are few in number, only 905 having been found in the census.

The methods of fishing and the instruments employed are many and varied. Of fixed engines the most familiar is the *bendi jāl*, consisting of a line of nets fastened across a tidal channel and leading to a basket trap of split bamboos; or a submerged sandbank may be surrounded with a bamboo or net enclosure, called *ber* or *chali*, which confines the fish as the tide recedes. Again, *bāndhs*, or plain screens of split bamboos, are to be seen fastened across nearly every water-course, often seriously obstructing the passage of boats. Of nets the commonest are the cast nets, or *jhānki*, made in various sizes and of various meshes, and the *behāl* or *dharma jāl*, two very similar nets, one triangular and the other quadrangular, fixed to a bamboo lever by means of which they are lowered into the water and raised again when a fish passes. Drag nets of different makes with or without pockets are worked with the help of boats, and sometimes the fishermen trawl a kind of net called *moi*, and in the shallows handnets not unlike those used on the English coasts for shrimping (*dharma jāl* or *jele jāl*) are employed. Besides these, there are several kinds of "gill" nets, known generally by the name of the fish for the capture of which they are adapted. Of purse nets a good example is the *suti jāl*, in the shape of a long funnel which is kept open by the stream. Down this funnel the fish drift and are entangled in the narrow end, from which they are taken from time to time by the fishermen. In shallow waters a cane basket shaped like a bell jar with an open neck (*polo*) is often used. It is plunged suddenly into the water and the fish found inside are taken out by hand through the opening at the top. Fish are also speared with the *konch* or *tentha* and are caught with a rod and line or with set lines. For the *koi* a fine split bamboo is used instead of a hook. The bamboo is bent, and its sharp ends are kept in position by means of the grass-hopper used as bait, and when a fish swallows this the points are released and spring apart piercing his gullet. As a rule the boats used for fishing are dugouts, (*kundā*, *dongā*, or *gāchh*) made from the trunks of palm, mango, sāl, chaplās, simul and other trees, hollowed out. The *sharanga* is a larger and more shapely boat requiring two men to work it, but is also fashioned from a scooped out trunk.

Fish.

The list of the varieties of fish caught in the district is too long to find place in this volume. The members of the carp tribe (Cyprinidæ), *ruhit* (Labeo ruhita), *katāl* (Catla Buchanani), *mrigāl* (Cyrrhiria mrigala), and *kalabāus* (Labeo calbasu) are plentiful and occupy the first place in popular estimation. Of other varieties the *chapila* (Clupea chapra), *phalai* (Notoptonis kapirat), *chital* (Notoptonis chitala), *pābda* (Callichrous paoda), *bachā* (Entropiichthys vacha), *bole* (Gobius giuris and Gobius kokins), *jaki* or *gaui* (Ophiocephalus punctatus), *sol* (Ophiocephalus striatus), *jengra* (macrones of several kinds), *magur* (Clarious magur), *singi* (Saccobranchus fossilis) and *koi* (Anabas scandens or climbing perch) are thought to be good eating. The last three are in great demand as nourishing food for invalids. Of estuarine fish the most esteemed are the *rishya* or *topsi* (Polynemus paradiscus) commonly known as the mango fish, the *bhetki* or *korāl* (Lates calcarifar), the *bata* or *khoshrul* (Mugil corsula) and the *hilsa* (Clupeo ilisha), of which the first three are common. The *hilsa* is becoming scarce and it is said that those caught at the mouth of the Meghnā are not so good to eat as those from the higher reaches of the river. *Muralla, punti, kholisha* and *chela* are small fish and are found all over the district in great abundance, and though not so much relished as the choicer species, make up between them the major part of the fish consumed in the district. Prawns, crayfish (*ichha*), and crabs, are caught in numbers and always find a ready sale. It is impossible to state accurately the total weight or value of the annual catch, but the report puts it at about 300,000 maunds, or enough to allow each fish-eating member of the community an ounce a day. This is nothing like equal to the demand, and there is a general impression that the supply is diminishing, and this is accounted for chiefly by the contraction of the fishing grounds owing to the steady silting up of the water channels and to the reclamation of swamps. Nearly all the extensive marshes which existed thirty years ago in the centre of the district have been reclaimed and the formation of *char* Jabar between the larger islands and the mainland, and the increase of the banks in the Meghnā seems to have interfered with fishing in the estuary. The report suggests that the wholesale destruction of fry involved in the methods by which fish are caught is partly responsible. It would be difficult to regulate the methods of capture or to place any restriction on the size of fish caught, but the tanks found in every village might afford the means of replenishing the supply of at least the more valuable species. Carp are said not to breed in tanks, but the young thrive well when put in, and a good many private tanks are periodically restocked with fry, generally young carp brought from Chittagong, but the practice is not so universal as it ought to be, and unfortunately the tank is too often drained dry every year, which means of course the destruction of all the immature fish.

Weaving

In the year 1756 a cloth factory was established by the East India Company at Jagdia, near the mouth of the Feni river, and about the same time or soon afterwards other factories were started at Kalyāndi (Colinda), Lakhipur, and Charpātā, while the French also had a factory near Jagdia. In these factories cotton cloth, known as *bafta*, was manufactured. The indigenous cloth seems to have been inferior, for in a letter written by the Chittagong Council on the 16th February 1761 it is thus described * :—

"The manufacture of this country is at present very indifferent, all piece-goods being of a thick woolly quality in no way durable, and short in length and breadth. This may be improved by making the combs of the looms closer, spinning the thread harder and more even, and striking them fuller." Cotton of poor quality was grown in the hills and also in Sandwīp, and in the early correspondence we find the Company much concerned in the means for improving it by the introduction of new seed or improved cultivation. Down to the year 1820 the industry appears to have flourished. Mr. Walters found many weavers in Bāmni and Sandwīp, and cotton was then grown in the islands, though the principal factory was at Lakhipur in the west of the district. After that, owing, it is said, to the competition of English piece-goods, the industry declined, and about 1828 the factories were closed. In 1876-77 it was reported that *dhutis*, *sāris*, *gamchas*, and other cotton cloths were made in small quantities for local use, but that the importation of cheap English piece-goods had reduced considerably the local manufactures. Of late years, however, there has been some revival. Besides the ordinary *sāris* and *dhutis* of coarse white cotton, checks and coloured cloths, both thick and thin, suitable for coats, shirts, etc., are woven. *Lungis* of superior quality in fast colours are being made in Noākhāli, and compete successfully with those imported from Holland and Burma. A species of coloured *sāri*, known as *jām sāri*, is now much in vogue among Muhammadan women, and is woven in the district, or imported from Mainamāti. It is said that about one thousand rupees worth of these *sāris* is sold on every *hāt* day at Chaumuhani †. The mosquito nets of Chaumuhani, white and coloured, have also a great reputation. Unfortunately, taking advantage of the increased demand for their goods, the weavers of Noākhāli have tried to impose upon the public cloths of inferior yarn, to the great injury of their trade. All local cloth is made with imported yarn, chiefly from the Bombay mills.

Iron and steel work.

From Mr. Jackson's Monograph on the iron and steel work of Bengal, it appears that he found 150 forges in Noākhāli

* Cotton's Revenue History of Chittagong, page 161.

† Survey of Industries and Resources of Eastern Bengal and Assam for 1907-08.

employing 600 persons. As a rule the work turned out is of the roughest, but at Dattapārā cutlery of fair quality is manufactured.*

Brass, copper and bellmetal.

The brass and bell-metal utensils made in the district are of inferior quality.

Mats and baskets.

Excellent baskets of many shapes and qualities are made from reed and cane, and in the east of the district very fine *pātis* or mats are prepared from a plant known as *mortāg* or *murtā*.

Imports and exports.

The external trade of the district is carried on by rail, steamer, country boats, and carts, and as statistics are available only for the first two of these, it is impossible to give any estimate of the total trade of the district. The chief imports are piece-goods, of which according to the published returns for the year 1908-09 about three-quarters are of European make, salt, kerosine oil, mustard oil, tobacco, sugar, brass and bell-metal articles, china and earthenware, and betel-leaves. Coal and coke also are imported in considerable quantities, and the latter is gradually coming into use for cooking, as fuel becomes more scarce. The chief export of the district is rice, most of which is carried to Calcutta by river. Next to this come betel-nuts, which are sent to Chittagong, Calcutta, and other districts, and from the markets in the north-west of the district considerable quantities of betel-nut paper (the inner skin of the sheaf covering the bunches of nuts) are sent to Burma where they are used to make wrappers for cheroots. This trade is in the hands of Burmese and a special enquiry made in 1908 showed that some 430 maunds of this substance, which sells at about two annas a seer had been exported from Sonaimura and Chaumuhani. Other articles exported are coco-nuts, linseed, chillies, onions, hides, fowls' eggs, raw cotton, and jute. The recorded exports of jute in 1908-09 were 212,477 maunds, a figure far in excess of that for any previous year.

Marts.

The chief marts and the principal objects of trade in the district are:—

(1) Rāipur on the Dākātiā: export of betel-nut, chillies, oranges, limes and plantains.

(2) Chaumuhani on the railway and only a mile from Begamganj *thānā*: jute, linseed, eggs, rice, oranges, and country cloth.

(3) Nadona in the north of the district connected with Noākhāli and Lāksām by road and waterways: rice and plantains.

(4) Lakhipur in the west of the district: a large business in molasses.

(5) Bhawāniganj in the south-east, connected by steamer with Barisāl: betel-nuts and *pān* as well as molasses and other articles; ranks next after Raipur and Chaumuhani.

* Survey of Industry and Resources of Eastern Bengal and Assam, 1907-08

(6) Sāntāsitā in Sudharām *thānā:* cattle, betel-nuts, cocoanuts, rice, chillies, etc.

(7) Chāprāsir Hāt on the *khāl* of that name: a large cattle market.

(8) Sonāgāzi in *thānā* Feni: timber, rice, linseed, and chillies.

(9) Pashurām in *thānā* Chhāgalnāia: fine mats and rice; famous for its *chirā*.

(10) Chāri Ānir Hāt, the principal mart of Sandwīp: cocoanuts.

Exhibitions.

In 1886 a considerable sum of money was raised, and a successful Agricultural and Industrial Exhibition was held in Sudharām. In 1904 again a sum of money raised for the purpose of a memorial to Queen Victoria was devoted to an exhibition, and this was continued for two years more until funds ran low. In March 1910 an agricultural exhibition was held in Sudharām and proved a success.

CHAPTER X.

LAND REVENUE ADMINISTRATION.

Fiscal divisions.

There is no record of the system of revenue administration before Noākhāli came under Muhammadan influence, and not much information is to be had before the middle of the eighteenth century. Though Bhulua was included in the revenue assessment of Akbar's minister, Todar Mal, in the year 1582, it is obvious from what has been said already that the Mughal governors were not then in a position to collect revenue from it. During the next 150 years Bhulua, originally an undivided Hindu *rāj*, became completely Muhammadanised and was split up into a number of *parganas* or fiscal divisions.

The origin of some of these *parganas* is obscure, but in a few cases it is possible to trace their history. Jagdia, Dāndra, and Allahābād, were all at one time part of Bhulua, but after the defeat of the Arakanese in the year 1610 two generals, one Hindu and one Muhammadan, were appointed to guard the frontiers against invasion, and received grants of land, that given to the Hindu became in course of time *pargana* Jagdia, and the other being again divided formed the two *parganas* of Dāndra and Allahābād, which were treated as one estate. Kanchanpur is said to have been carved out of Bhulua and Singhergān by the Emperor Feroz Shāh and given to the Muhammadan *Pīr* Khandkar Mīr Ahmad; while Ambarābād, then covered with jungle, was granted by Muhammad Shāh to Amānulla and Sanāulla Khān of Delhi at the instance of *Pīr* Ambar Shāh.

In the revised revenue roll of Bengal for the year 1728 we find Bhulua divided into eleven *parganas* or estates, which with the islands of Sandwīp and its appurtenances formed part of Chakla Jahāngirnagar in the province of Dacca.

Each of these *parganas* was assigned to one or more persons, who under the designation of *zamīndār*, *chaudhri*, or *dīwān*, was responsible for the collection of the revenue and the payment of the assigned quota into the Nawab's Treasury, and also for the maintenance of law and order, while his accounts were kept by the *kānungo* of the *pargana* and a staff of village accountants (*patwāris*).

Early British settlements.

In course of time some changes were made in the boundaries of *parganas* and there are now 35 *parganas* recognised. In the thirty years preceding the grant of the *dīwāni* to the East India Company not much change was made in the arrangement of *parganas*, but the assessment was enormously increased, and as the Mughal hold on the country weakened, the whole system became more and more disorganised, so that in 1772 when

the Directors decided to take the collections and the administration into their own hands, they had the greatest difficulty in obtaining correct information or accounts. They decided in the first place to farm out estates for five years to the highest bidders with the result that endless confusion was caused, and when fresh settlements were made in 1777 A.D. preference was given to the hereditary *zamīndārs*. The Regulations of the 10th February 1790 provided for a ten years' settlement of Bengal, but the application of this order to the districts of Tippera and Chittagong was postponed and yearly settlements continued to be made down till 1793, the year of the permanent settlement.

Mughal administration.

Of the early settlements on the mainland there is little record beyond what is to be found in published reports, but Mr. Duncan, to whose report reference has been made before, has left behind much valuable information as to Sandwīp. *Pargana* Sandwīp, which comprised the islands of Sandwīp, Hātia, Bāmni, and Shāgird-dihi, was in the year 1662, the *jāgir* of the Amir-ul-Omrah, and afterwards that of Nawāb Ibrahim Khān, and from the year 1713 that of Mir Jumla. When the management was first entrusted to an *ahdadār* does not appear; but there was one before the year 1753. The *pargana* was divided into three *tarafs* or shares known as the Niāmati, Musapur, and Rāmpur *tarafs*, the owners of which possessed some lands jointly and some separately. At first these divisions seem to have been unrecognised by the Mughal governors, and in 1716 when the islands were measured, the *āmin* divided the assessment in proportion to the land actually in possession of the co-sharers. The lands, both *maujūd* and *makhlūt* (original and added lands), were surveyed again in the years 1733 and 1743, and the proportions readjusted. The last measurement was made in 1763 when Bhawāni Charan was found in possession of 11 annas 4 *gandas* odd. In the meantime Bhawāni Charan had caused his name to be registered as *zamīndār* of an 11 annas 18 *gandas* 1 *kara* share, and the *kanungos*, to whom the point was referred, ruled that he could claim no abatement on the ground that he was actually in possession of less than his recorded share. They based the ruling on the ground that Sandwīp was a *tahudi mahāl*, that is, one the revenue of which was fixed, and not a *hasb-ul-wusuli mahāl*, a class of estate in which the proprietor was liable to pay his whole collections less the proportion allowed him.

Voluation.

In the assessment of 1763 the lands were divided into full rated (*puradar*) and low rated (*kamdar*) lands. It was assumed that in every four *kānis* of first class cultivated land one produced 25 *kannuas** of grain, one 20, one 17½, and one 10, giving an average of 18⅛; one-fifth of this was deducted as the '*patta* privilege' of the *tālukdār*,† and half the residue or 7¼ *kannuas* (valued

* This measure is not defined.

† *Talukdar*, i.e., the holder of an intermediate tenure, *vide* page 79.

at 1¼ *kannuas* per rupee) was the measure of the rent to be paid by the *tālukdār* to the *zamīndār*. First class fallow lands were valued at five-eighths of the rate for cultivated land. Inferior cultivated lands and fallow lands were valued at half the rates for the best class.

Abwabs. The assessment thus made constituted the *tashkisi jama*, but this was subsequently increased by several *abwābs*, *viz.*, *mathaut*, an allowance to the *Nāib ahdadār* levied at 2 annas 17 *gandas* per rupee on the *tashkis* rent, *māshki* levied at 1 anna 7 *gandas* per rupee, and *dihi kharcha* (local expenses) also collected at 1 anna 7 *gandas* per rupee. The rates of collection of these *abwābs* varied in the different divisions, and they were not always shown in the accounts.

The *tālukdārs* complained bitterly of these additions to their rental, which amounted in 1787 to 5 annas 11 *gandas* per rupee on the *tashkis* revenue of the 12 annas estate; the *zamīndārs* agreed to reduce them to 4 annas, and this arrangement was allowed to continue pending a fresh measurement and assessment.

The regulations for the permanent settlement required all *abwābs* to be amalgamated with the rent, but many of these separate payments continued to be exacted. Even now in most estates the following will be found:—*punya*, a present, usually one rupee, to the landlord on the first day of the *zamindāri* year; *piyāda*, a small fee to a peon deputed specially to summon the tenant; *mārchā*, a fine on marriage of the ryot's son or daughter; *amlā*, a present to the servants of the estate; *salāmi*, a fee to the landlord on special occasions. These miscellaneous payments are often included in agreements taken from tenants, so that they may be recoverable at law.

Classification of lands. The classification of the lands of Sandwīp is not easy to follow, but apparently the system was as follows:—The first division was into *taraf*, *maujūd*, and *makhlūt*, lands; the *chaudhuris* being accountable for the revenue of the first division, while by the custom of Sandwīp the management of the other classes was in the hands of the *ahdadārs*.* The *taraf* lands seem to have been those separately possessed by different *chaudhuris*, the *maujūd* being the undivided assessed lands and the *makhlūt* additions to this area by reclamation and accretion. The lands (query *taraf* lands only) were again classified as *huzerea* (probably *huzuri*), *nij-tāluks*, and *khudkāsht*.† On the first class, which formed much the largest part and seems to have been let out in *tāluks*, the *zamīndārs* (*chaudhuris*) retained only the cess known as *māshki*, the *tālukdārs* paying the rest of their rent to the *ahdadār*. On the *nij-tāluks* they seem to have enjoyed the *tālukdār's* share (one-fifth of the produce), and on the *khudkāsht* they paid the nominal valuation but the *ahdadār* was expected

* Paras. 420, etc., of Mr. Duncan's report.
† Op cit., para. 443.

not to exact the full value of the produce or to enquire too closely into the profits. A similar arrangement appears to have prevailed in Bhulua which had been managed by *ahdadārs*. The correspondence of 1790 shows that the *makhlāt* lands of Bhuluā were undivided and were managed directly by Government; but the information obtainable is fragmentary.

Land revenue.

The following table compares the past and present land revenue of the principal *parganas*; the early figures being based on Grant's View of the Revenues of Bengal. :—

Name of pargana.	Land Revenue in 1728 A.D.			Land revenue in 1765.	Present land revenue.	Remarks.
	Khālisa.	Jāgir.	Total.			
	Rs.	Rs.	Rs.	Rs.	Rs.	
Bhulua ...	14,271	26,891	41,162	1,35,982	1,23,929	In the year 1790 the revenue was Rs. 1,06,487.
Jagdia ...	...	16,984	16,984	17,734	28,705	
Dāndra and Illahābād.	2,348	5,138	7,486	48,638	18,768	These were long under *khās* management.
Bābupur ...	350	...	350	12,984	14,952	
Gopālpur Mirzanagar.	3,106	...	3,106	15,889	21,060	
Ambarābād ...	289	...	289	...	81,633	The land was covered with forest when first granted.
Shaistānagar ...	993	...	993	...	14,848	Ditto.
Kanchanpur ...	2,090	...	2,090	...	6,365	
Sandwip ...	54,696	...	54,696	1,08,470	1,52,105	

It is necessary to explain that the lands of all estates were divided into (1) *Khālisa*, (2) *Jāgir*; the revenue from the former being payable into the imperial treasury, and that from the latter appropriated to local expenditure, the large proportion of jāgir in Bhulua and its vicinity being for the support of the force necessary to protect the frontier against the Maghs and Tipperas.

It is doubtful whether the revenue shown for the year 1765 was collected, and certainly the enhancement made in the

preceding 37 years got no further than the local officials. Fuller details regarding Sandwīp are to be had in Mr. Duncan's report, and may serve as an example of the course in other estates.

Revenue of Sandwip.

In the year 1662 the *māl* revenue, that is, the revenue from the land, was only Rs. 6,667. In 1713 nearly Rs. 4,000 were added in the guise of *lawāziṃāt*. In 1728 a lump addition (*nazarāna*) of Rs. 4,000 was made, and other similar additions raised the *māl* revenue by 1751 A.D. to Rs. 22,793. In 1753 a new *ahdadār* was appointed, and payments to numerous officers and for police and other establishments increased the assessment by Rs. 14,000, but this seems to have been too much, for four years later another *ahdadār* was appointed and allowed a remission of Rs. 4,500. In 1763 Bishnu Charan Bose became *ahdadār* and gave an agreement to pay *dāsmāsha* rupees in place of the Arcot rupees that were the ordinary currency in the island, thus adding about 9 per cent. to his real payment. Large remissions were allowed in the next two years for inundation and *nājāy* (deficits) reducing the revenue at the time of the assumption of the Diwāni to Rs. 20,500. In 1772 the Committee of Revenue assessed the *pargana* at Rs. 77,974, of which Rs. 39,710 was subsequently determined to be the share of the *māl* revenue, and in 1777 the revenue was fixed at Rs. 50,584. The *jama wāsil bāki* enables us to compare this revenue with the actual receipts. In 1765 the gross rental was shown as Rs. 80,213, but of this Rs. 1,657 was postponed for the following year and the actual amount realised was Rs. 72,558, on which a *batta* or reduction for loss on light and base coins of Rs. 7,591 was allowed. The net realisations came to Rs. 65,000 Arcot rupees equivalent to about 59,000 *sikka*, so that the *zamindārs*, or rather the *ahdadārs*, retained in that year more than Rs. 38,000. In 1775 the collections from the land came to over Rs. 71,000 *sikka*, so that the enhanced revenue of the following year must have left the *zamindārs* with a substantial margin.

Sair revenue.

In the Mughal times *zamindārs* were allowed to levy tolls and landing dues, and enjoyed the profits of salt manufacture and markets The total of this *sair* revenue of Sandwīp was in 1662 A.D. Rs. 23,864. Small additions, chiefly as *nazar* to new governors, were made from time to time down to 1751, when Rs. 5,615 was added for the Mahratta *chaut*, Rs. 1,100 for *khāsnavisi*, and Rs. 26,250 as a premium of 14 annas per rupee on a fictitious annual advance of Rs. 30,000 from the governor, thus bringing the total to Rs. 60,717. In 1763 the demand stood at Rs. 72,056, but of this Rs. 18,400 were subsequently remitted on account of losses. The assessment made in 1772 did not distinguish *māl* from *sair* revenue in the first instance, but when the Company decided to resume all *sair* collections as a preliminary to the decennial settlement, the share of the total to be remitted on this account was fixed at Rs. 38,264, though the accounts of

the *pargana* do not show that a quarter of that sum was collected as *sair*.

Permanent settlement.

In the permanent settlement all distinction of *khālisa* and *jāgir* was abolished and lands of every description were made liable for the land revenue, which was fixed so as to leave the proprietor a net income, including profits from private lands, of 10 per cent. of the collections, but this proportion could be exceeded in the case of petty properties or for special reasons. In Noākhāli a good many estates were for some time on the Collector's hands and the revenue was fixed practically by a compromise.

The land revenue of Noākhāli amounted in 1842-43 to Rs. 5,31,775; in 1908-09 it was Rs. 7,24,678. The large increase is to be attributed to the assessment of new alluvial formations. The incidence per acre of cropped land is a little under 12 annas.

Estates.

All interests in land may be classified as either (1) estates, in which no interest intervenes between the proprietor and Government, (2) intermediate tenures, or (3) cultivators' holdings.

Estates are again sub-divided into revenue-paying and revenue-free, and the former of these classes into permanently settled, temporarily settled, and Government estates.

In 1908-09 there were 1,545 permanently settled estates with a land revenue of Rs. 4,51,658; 45 temporarily settled estates with a revenue of Rs. 52,859, and 245 Government estates with a demand of Rs. 2,12,947. Of these estates 128 represent whole and broken *parganas*. The policy of the decennial and permanent settlements required one *zamīndār* to be responsible for each estate, and every portion of a *pargana* in separate possession of one *zamīndār*, or a separate group of *zamīndārs*, became an estate; and after the permanent settlement provision was made for the partition of estates at the instance of any one of the proprietors.

Taluks.

In the eighteenth century a great part of Noākhāli was in the hands of intermediate tenure-holders. They were recognised in the assessments made by the Mughal administrators and were allowed a fifth of the gross estimated rental.

The Regulations for the decennial settlement provided for the separation of certain classes of *tāluks* (Ar. ta'aluk=dependant) or tenures from the parent estate, *viz.*, those that had existed before the estate, had been created by a superior authority, or had been conceded the privilege by the deed of creation (*vide* Regulations of 23rd November 1791), and the *tālukdārs* were encouraged though not compelled to seek such separation. Those who asked for and were found entitled to separation were admitted to engage at a revenue calculated to leave them an income of a tenth of the gross assets including the profits from their *Nānkar* lands. Such *tāluks* are known as *khārija tāluks*; they are permanently settled and differ only in their origin from the

zamindāri estates. The number of estates so created in Noākhāli was returned as 2,181. There remained about 500 *tāluks* created before the permanent settlement which were not entitled to separation. They are called *petāo* (from the word *pet*=belly) and are the highest class of subordinate tenure. A *haulā* (Ar. *hawāla*= trust) is very similar to a *petāo tāluk* in its incidents, both being permanent, heritable, and divisible; but while there may be a *haulā* under a *tāluk* the order is never reversed. A *shikmi* tenure is similar in its incidents, but is subordinate to a *tāluk* or a *hāula*.

The term *hāula* appears to have been applied in the first instance to a commission granted to a man of energy and capital who undertook to bring newly formed land into cultivation, but in course of time it came into general use to designate a permanent hereditary tenure usually at fixed rates of rent. It is a term of great respectability, and many substantial cultivators call themselves *hāuladār* though they have no real title to the name. In early settlements it was customary to allow *hāuladārs* more favourable rates than were given to common cultivators, and they usually had the benefit of a deduction (*mutton*)* of from two and a half to ten per cent. from the measured area besides an allowance of $\frac{1}{32}$nd for the *ails* or ridges between the fields. This perhaps took the place of the different lengths of rod used in *zamindāri* estates for different classes of tenants. Many of these *tāluks* and *hāulas* are in fact *patni tāluks* subject to the provisions of Regulation VIII of 1819 and liable as such to be brought to sale by the Collector for default in payment of the rent, while the holders are bound to furnish security for their rent and good conduct, if so required. These permanent tenure-holders can devise similar rights to under-tenure-holders; thus under the patni may be found a *darpatni* and under that a *sepatni*. Below the *hāula* may be found a *nim hāula* or *osat hāula*, and below the *shikmi tāluk* a *darshikmi*. *Jangalburi ābādkari tāluks* are found in Sandwīp. They were granted at a progressive rent for the purpose of bringing waste lands under cultivation. The course of reclamation of *char* lands is usually as follows :—As soon as the new formation ceases to be overflowed by a normal tide, the landlord enters into a *gorkati* or grazing settlement with some contractor. When the grass and bush spring up roving herdsmen (Bāthaniā) come with their herds of cattle and bivouac on the *char* paying to the contractor a rent of so much a head for their cattle and a small fee for fuel. In course of time the land becomes fit for the plough, and formerly at this stage a *hāula* or *ābādkāri* lease would have been granted, but now a days it is usual to settle the land directly with ryots, who build temporary sheds and migrating there during the cultivating season with their plough and cattle begin to grow

Reclamation leases.

* This was given also to *tālukdārs*. In early settlements it appears as a deduction from the area, in later ones as a deduction from the rate.

paddy. Later on as the land rises, they build permanent houses, dig arge tanks to procure a supply of fresh water, and plant round them betel, cocoanut and date-palms, plantains, *māndār* and other trees. They dig drains, throwing up the earth to form pathways among their scattered homesteads, and thus they settle with their families. The whole district has been formed and settled in this way from one end to the other. Formerly tenants for such newly formed land were in great demand and obtained very favourable terms. Mr. Walters reported that in 1819 new settlers on the *chars* of Hātia paid no rent for eight years and thereafter low rates for several years more; even now they begin with low rates, paying in the first year only six annas an acre for *degichar* or *malanghi char** or lands still submerged at high tide. The rent is usually progressive, and higher rates also on a progressive scale are fixed after the land becomes culturable.

Ryots.

Though certain portions of the lands are cultivated by tenure-holders and petty proprietors with the aid of hired labourers, the great bulk of the cultivation is in the hands of hereditary cultivators, whose rents were regulated formerly by custom and now by the provisions of the Bengal Tenancy Act. At the time of the permanent settlement the ryots of Noākhāli rarely occupied the same land continuously for any length of time; they wandered from village to village, paying rent only for such lands as they actually cultivated. In Sandwīp, which had an earlier civilization, cultivation seems to have been less fluctuating. Mr. Duncan in his report of 1778 gives a translation of a typical ryoti lease, in which the lands are classified as ryoti, *kharsha*, and *barga*, and explains that the ryoti is that part of the tenure which the ryot is not at liberty to relinquish but must be answerable for the cultivation and revenue of it at the hazard of forfeiting his possession. The rent of the *kharsha* land was also payable in money but the tenant could relinquish the cultivation of it when he pleased. The *barga* was land for which a portion of the actual produce was deliverable as rent.

Coming down to the nineteenth century we find a distinction drawn between *khudkāsht* or resident ryots, holding under *zamīndārs* or *tālukdārs*, and *jotdārs* cultivating under *hāuladārs*; more favourable terms being allowed to the former. The distinction is known no longer and the term *jotdār* means any cultivating tenant, ryot implying residence in the locality. In Chakla Bāmni (and probably elsewhere) a *jotdār* is a yearly tenant.

Transfers.

The relations of ryots with their landlords are now governed by the provisions of the Bengal Tenancy Act, and most of them have rights of occupancy. These rights are not transferable without the consent of the landlord, but in practice are sold at from

* *Malanghi*=a salt maker. Such lands were used formerly for making salt.

Rs. 150 to Rs. 200 per *kāni*,* or roughly at from £12 to £16 an acre, and in many estates the transfer is recognised on payment of a fee, usually 25 per cent. of the purchase money. The Bhulua *zamīndārs*, however, refuse to recognise such purchasers and make it a rule to evict them. According to the registration returns the occupancy rights in some 500 acres of land were sold in 1909 at an average price of about £9-10-0 an acre. Hardly any ryots nowadays pay produce rents.

Under-ryots. Under-ryots in Noākhāli have no occupancy rights, but it is recorded in the Settlement report of Chakla Bāmni that under-ryots' rights are sold, though *jotdāri* rights are not. Some of them pay produce rents and are regarded either as tenants or as labourers according to the circumstances of the case.

They are known as *osat-ryot*, and a further stage of sub-leasing is recognised in the *dar-osat-ryot*.

The distinction between tenure-holder, ryot, and under-ryot made by the Bengal Tenancy Act has given rise to difficulties in this district, where the holdings are often very large and the *jotdārs* arrogate to themselves the title of *hāuladār*. The Settlement Officer reports that in the settlements of Government *chars* made about 1876 the *hāuladārs* holding more than 100 *bighās* were treated as tenure-holders unless the whole area was in their own cultivating possession, and those holding less were classed as ryots unless the greater part was sublet—the under-tenants in either case being treated as *jotdārs* with occupancy rights. That a tenant can keep so much land in his own hands is due to the system of cultivation in the *chars*. The cultivators do not live there, but go for a short time in the spring and get the land ploughed and sown by hired labour—for which they pay very high—and then leave the rice plants alone until harvest time when they return with an army of hired reapers, cut, thresh, stack, and sell the paddy on the spot.

Revenue policy in 1821. On the formation of the district the Board of Revenue set out their views and their policy in a letter of 46 paragraphs, which even now will repay perusal. The Board advised Mr. Plowden not to institute resumption proceedings in petty cases, and to alleviate hardship by allowing progressive revenue. One part of their instructions is particularly interesting as showing how the severity of the regulations was softened down in practice. The assessment of *mālikāna* was to be made on the principle of estimating the gross produce at 15 per cent. above the farming *jama* if the lands were let in farm, or at the net rent if *khās*, a moiety of which was to constitute the demands of Government, leaving as *mālikāna* to the proprietor the difference between that moiety and the *jama* at which the farmer had engaged. They give as an example the case of a property of which the

* Based on the Collector's report.

former revenue was Rs. 800, the gross assets were assumed to be Rs. 920, of which Government took Rs. 460, leaving Rs. 340 as *mālikanā* to the recusant proprietor. They urged the Collector to take steps for the survey of his charge, and said that they expected that he would with indefatigable industry and research discover the material records of the office of the former Collectorate at Bhulua; but this last injunction does not seem to have been complied with.

Sub-infeudation.

Tenures are exceedingly numerous in Noākhāli and sub-infeudation prevails to a deplorable extent. Exact statistics are not to be had without much labour, but the number of tenures assessed to cess is 167,305, greater than in any district of Eastern Bengal except Bākarganj and 2½ times as many as in the adjoining district of Tippera. Mr. Cumming's account of sub-infeudation in Chakla Roshnābād * may be taken as applicable to the district as a whole. He writes :—"In the area held by tenure-holders it may be generally asserted that the prevailing feature is not sub-infeudation, but sub-division. There is sub-infeudation, but not to the extent which exists in the neighbouring district of Bāckergunge or in the Sadar part of Noākhāli. One instance found was as follows :—proprietor, then a taluk, then a dar-taluk, then a patni, then a dar-patni and then the raiyat. Herein are four intermediaries between the cultivator and the Raj. The process of sub-division is the result partly of inheritance, especially amongst Muhammadans, and of transfers; but the sub-division is principally due to the system under which tenures were created without definite areas in a country in which and at a time when spontaneous increase of cultivated area was both possible and permissible. The result is an intermixture of tenures similar to that existing amongst the estates in Muzaffarpur and Chittagong. Anomalies of course are discovered when the record of rights is prepared. Several taluks are found to be holding some lands jointly, but the holders cannot say what the proportionate share of each taluk is. This is the chrysalis stage. Again, certain land is recorded as held jointly (ijmali) under several taluks and the shares are settled; but the holders of the taluks are receiving rents from the tenants out of proportion to the nominal shares. This is a further development, in which the weaker go to the wall. The last stage is when the area originally held jointly has been parcelled out by mutual arrangement, so that each taluk has the entire possession of the lands allotted to it (chinnit dakhal). The more inchoate the stage of growth of the tenure, the greater is the difficulty of record." The Sub-divisional Officer of Feni reports that in *pārgana* Amirābād alone there are 300 taluks, and in Bedarābād 800, and that the sub-infeudation and the intermixture of joint and several tenure is most complex. One peculiarity in the tenures of these *parganas* is that the owner of half the estate

* Paragraph 63, Report on the Settlement of Chakla Roshnabād.

let out his share in *tāluki* lease in 1866, while the same *tāluk-dārs* took fresh settlements three years later from the sixteen annas' proprietors preserving intact the former agreements. The forms of intermediate tenures are numerous. Under the landlords we find *pātni tāluks*, *kāimi tāluks*, *kāimi hāulās*, occupancy holdings and non-occupancy holdings; under the *pātni* tenures there are *dar-pātnis* and *se-pātnis* and beneath any one of these there may be in succession *tapas*, *shikmi tapas*, and *dar-shikmi tapas*, *kāimi jots* (ryots at fixed rates), and ordinary ryoti holdings. Beneath the *kāimi tāluk* come *dar-tāluks*, *shikmi tāluks* and *dar-shikmi tāluks*, and beneath any of these there may be *tapas*, *hāulas*, ryots at fixed rates, etc. Beneath the *hāulā* there may be a *nim hāulā*, and under that a *tapa*, and so on.

Government Estates.

After the Permanent Settlement Government acquired by purchase portions of estates sold to liquidate arrears of revenue, many new islands became its property under the law of alluvion, some invalid grants in Government estates were resumed, and a few properties escheated to Government. Most of these were farmed or let for short terms on *ābādkāri tālukdāri* tenures, the lessee undertaking to bring a certain area into cultivation during the term, and receiving 15 per cent. or more on the total collections. In 1861 the Board's decision to allow only annual leases provoked a protest from the Collector; but about the same time attempts were made to sell the Government estates, though the undeveloped condition of many made it hopeless to expect a full price. Ultimately 68 estates with an area of 80,443 acres have been sold for Rs. 4,12,512, subject to an annual revenue of Rs. 1,27,583. Others have been settled for varying periods, generally with neighbouring proprietors; and there remained in 1909 A.D. 245 estates with a gross revenue of Rs. 2,12,947 in the possession of Government. Of these 34 with a revenue of Rs. 58,638 are in *pargana* Sandwīp, seven with a revenue of Rs. 10,002 in Bhulua, and 68 with a revenue of Rs. 1,40,804 are in the islands of the Meghnā, *pargana* Zāzirah.* There are three administrative divisions in charge of a Deputy Collector at headquarters and of Sub-Deputy Collectors on Sandwīp and Hātiā, and ten tahsīl circles. The cost of management comes to 9 per cent. of the revenue demand, and the total outgoings on management and improvements are about Rs. 24,000 a year. In 1907-08 the number of certificates filed for the recovery of arrears of rent was 1,957, and only Rs. 7,587 were remitted. In the ten years ending in 1904-05 more than the total demand for the period was collected, but there have been large enhancements since then. For the years 1896—1901 the average demand was Rs. 1,12,000 a year and for the next five years Rs. 1,45,000 a year. The increase is due to the formation of new and improvement of older *chars*, which necessitate constant settlement and re-settlement.

* Zāzirah means alluvial formation.

Temporarily settled estates.

There are 45 temporarily settled estates, paying a revenue of Rs. 52,859. They are scattered all over the district, but 14 with a revenue of Rs. 23,617 are in *pargana* Zāzirah.

Fishery estates.

The right of fishing in the tidal rivers belongs to the public and no charge is made for it. There are only two petty *jalkar mahāls*, one in the Dākātiā *Dona*, and the other in the Rahmat Ali *khāl*.

Revenue-free estates.

The Mughal Emperors from time to time granted lands free of revenue to holy men or to those who had done them service, and subordinate officials and even *zamīndārs* had made many such grants of the lands in their charge. In 1782 the 'Bāze Zāmin Daftār' was constituted to obtain a record of these grants, and Regulation XIX of 1793 defined the classes of grants that were to be recognised. All grants made before the year 1765 and in possession of the grantee were declared valid. Grants made between 1765 and 1790 were valid only if they had been made or confirmed by the Government, and grants of later date were declared null and void, whatever the length of possession. Government, however, claimed only the revenue to be derived from the resumption of grants of more than a hundred *bighās*, leaving the *zamīndārs* to apply for the resumption of smaller grants within their estates and to enjoy the profits. It was long before the investigation was completed, and ultimately 74 major grants were confirmed and became revenue-free estates, while the cess returns show 915 rent-free tenures within the ambits of estates.

The only revenue-free tenures in Noākhāli that call for special notice are the *khusbāsh lākhiraj* grants. This name was applied to the lands, originally 40 *drons*, occupied free of rent by the descendants of the garrison of 1,400 men sent to Bhulua in the seventeenth century to protect it from the incursions of the Maghs. In 1830 the tenures were resumed under the orders of the Board of Revenue, but in 1843 the persons in possession of 36 parcels of these lands were allowed to purchase the proprietary right free of revenue on payment of ten years' revenue.

Sale of estates.

Following the practice of their predecessors the East India Company used at first to recover arrears of revenue from proprietors or farmers by confining the defaulter and sending officers (*sazāwal*) to collect the rents directly. The sale of the property itself was introduced by the regulations for the decennial settlement which allowed the Board of Revenue with the sanction of the Governor-General to sell a portion of the estate in default sufficient for the liquidation of the balance due. Regulation III of 1794 exempted landholders from imprisonment for failure to pay the land revenue, but this exemption was withdrawn by Regulation VII of 1799, and down to 1841 imprisonment of the landholder and sale of the whole or a portion of his property continued to be alternative or supplementary methods of realising

arrears. The present law, Bengal Act XI of 1859, makes sale the only coercive measure and the whole property is liable to be sold for the most petty arrear unless any shares are protected by special registration, in which case they are to be sold only if the price fetched by the residue is less than the balance due. The number of such separate accounts registered was 851 in 1907-08.

It would be unprofitable to follow the long course of attachments and sales, but the result of them is that not a single *zamīndāri* estate remains in possession of the proprietors who held it when the district first came under British administration. It would not be fair to blame only the inelastic system for this : the records disclose a chronic state of quarrel and dispute among the *zamīndārs* that must of itself have proved the ruin of any estate.

Nowadays sales are infrequent ; in 1901-05 though 337 estates and shares of estates became liable to sale only 24 were sold ; and in the same period 85 tenures in Government estates were sold for arrears of rent. Revenue-paying estates fetch from 15 to 20 times the net profit.

Public demands recovery.

Arrears of public demands are recovered by means of certificates made under Bengal Act I of 1895 which have the force of a decree and are executed by attachment and sale of the defaulter's property.

In the ten years ending 1904-05 the average annual number of such certificates was just over 1,900 and in 1907-08 there were 3,122.

Land registration.

In 1907-08 there were 8,965 separate interests in estates recorded under Bengal Act VII of 1876. In the five years ending in 1905 the annual number of applications under the Act was nearly 600, and in 1907-08, 640 new interests were entered in the registers.

Kists.

The *kists* or instalments of rents vary in different estates. In Bhulua, Ambarābād, and some other estates the permanent tenures usually pay in ten instalments spread over the months of Baisākh to Māgh. Ryots usually pay in four instalments: in Bhulua, Ambarābād, and the 6 anna estate of Bābupur *pargana* these fall due in Āsārh, Āswin, Pous, and Chaitra. The Sub-divisional Officer of Feni reports that tenure-holders and ryots of the Courjon estates have to pay rent in 10 *kists*, and that at the end of the first month interest at one anna per rupee is due, at the end of the second *kist* two annas per rupee, and so on, until at the 10th *kist* a tenant in arrears has to pay double the original rent.*

Zamindars.

In the years that followed the Permanent Settlement all the big estates came to sale, and not one is now in possession of heirs of the original proprietors.

* This information was received too late for verification and coming from a reliable source has been entered; but I have never known such an arrangement.

The Administrator-General on behalf of Arun Chandra Singh and Satyendranāth Ghose of the Paikpārā family holds the great Bhulua estate, the six annas estate of Bābupur, nearly the whole of *pargana* Amirābād, and considerable properties in Sandwīp and the islands. The major portion of the old formations of Sandwīp, Hātiā, and Bāmni is shared by Mr. Delauney, Mrs. Massingham, and Shib Dulāl Tewāri—all foreigners. The largest estate in Omarābād belongs to Gobinda Chandra Singh and others of Murshidābād; Tappa Jaynagar belongs to a *zamīndār* of Muktagāchā. *Parganas* Bedarābād, Amirābād,* and Kādvā, formerly the property of the Rājā of Hill Tippera, were granted by him to Mr. Courjon and have passed into the possession of the heirs of Mahārājā Durga Charan Law. His Highness the Rājā of Hill Tippera owns 129½ square miles of Chakla Roshnābād and a fourth of *pargana* Dāndrā. In fine, except the Dālāl Bāzār *zamīndārs*, who are descended from the Banyan of Mr. Verelst, all the principal landowners are absentees.

* There are two Amirābāds.

CHAPTER XI.

GENERAL ADMINISTRATION.

Staff.

Noākhāli is a regulation district, that is to say, one in which the Bengal Regulations and all Acts applying to Bengal are in force unless expressly excluded. The head of the district is the Magistrate and Collector, who combines in one person magisterial, revenue and executive functions; as District Registrar he is the head of the local Registration Department, and as Chairman of the District Board has a general control over the communications, sanitation and primary education of the district. His superior staff for general administration consists of four Assistant or Deputy Magistrates, having also revenue powers, and a Sub-Deputy Collector, besides the staffs at Feni, Sandwīp and Hātia.

Sub-division.

Until the year 1876 the district was an undivided charge, but in that year *thānā* Chhāgalnāiya from Tippera and Mirkasarai from Chittagong were combined with *thānā* Feni to form the Feni sub-division; two years later Mirkasarai was retransferred to Chittagong. The sub-division is in charge of a Deputy Magistrate and Collector, who is immediately responsible for the administration of his charge, and though divorced from direct control of the specialised departments, such as Registration and Excise, is yet as the local representative of the district officer expected to keep an eye on them and bring to notice any defect.

Thanas.

The *thānā* was originally the seat of a *Faujdār*, but in its modern application means a police circle. These police circles were constituted originally under the provisions of the Regulations of 1793 and were supposed to have an area of 400 square miles. When the district was first formed there were included in it eight *thānās*, *viz.*, Sudharām, Begamganj, Lakhipur, Rāmganj, Amirgāon, Chāndia, Sandwīp, and Hātia, and since then there have been few changes.

The Dhanya Munya outpost of Chāndia was promoted later to be a *thānā*, and these two *thānās* were transferred to Bākarganj in 1869, while Chhāgalnāiya was added to Noākhāli in 1876.

Thānā Amirgāon was in the year 1875 removed to Farādnagar and was renamed Feni. A new *thānā* called Bāmni was opened in the south-east of the district, but in 1888 its name was changed to Companyganj, and it has been reduced to the status of an outpost under *thānā* Sudharām, so that at present there are eight *thānās* and one independent outpost in the district. Constituted purely for police purposes, the *thānā* has almost entirely superseded the *pargana* as a unit of revenue and general administration.

Villages.

The village never existed as an integral unit of administration in this part of Bengal. The cultivators in early days were nomadic and had no village organisation such as is found in western India; consequently the survey officers found it difficult to define the village, and though the *mauza*, as the villages of the revenue survey are termed, is the unit for revenue purposes, it was found so inconvenient that it was not followed in the census of 1901, for which the whole district was divided into one town and 2,633 villages. At present the groups of villages, known as *chaukidāri* unions, have to a great extent taken the place of the village as a unit.

Village servants.

There were very few village servants in the district. A certain number of *patwāris* or accountants did exist, but they were really the servants of the *zamīndārs* and tenure-holders, and at the present day though many people bear the title of *patwāri*, it is rather an honorary distinction, implying some degree of education, than an indication of an office.

Thirty years ago the village headmen, known as *mātabars* or *mahalladārs*, still enjoyed considerable dignity and power, but they have been almost entirely displaced by the *chaukidāri panchayets* described below.

Police.

The *chaudhuris* and other *zamīndārs* were under the Mughal administration responsible for the maintenance of peace and apprehension of offenders, but so far from doing their duty in this respect they seem to have been the chief supporters of dacoits. With the introduction of the farming system and the establishment of *faujdārs* they were relieved of this duty, but in 1782 a proclamation was issued by the Governor-General, ordering all *zamīndārs* "to erect *thānās*" in their respective jurisdictions. They were made liable to refund the value of any property stolen if they failed to recover it, and were warned that the penalty for complicity in robbery, murder or breach of the peace was death.

The Regulations of the 7th December 1792 relieved them of their responsibilities. *Thānās* were then formed and placed in charge of *darogas* who had under them a few *barkandāzes* (thunderbolt throwers or musqueteers) and were paid from the proceeds of a tax levied on traders and shop-keepers, and encouraged to energy by rewards for the apprehension of offenders. This system continued with few modifications until the passing of Act V of 1861 by which the organisation of the police is now regulated.

It was better than nothing, but in 1818 we find Mr. Walters pointing out the defects of the system, defects that survive in part to this day. The *barkandāzes* were underpaid and inefficient, the charges were too big, the police had such a bad name that respectable men would not serve as *darogas*, and several of these officers were found guilty of complicity in serious crime. The petty exactions of the police and the delays and expenses of justice deterred the people from reporting the

commission of offences; and above all he considered a river police absolutely essential to grapple with thefts and dacoity by gangs (*kāfila*) of professional thieves.

In 1860 the police force of Noākhāli consisted of 164 men and 37 officers. In 1908 there were a Superintendent, 3 Inspectors, 24 Sub-Inspectors, 36 head-constables, and 242 constables; or one policeman to every 3,707 inhabitants and every 5·3 square miles.

Of these a force of 25 men and 2 head-constables under a Sub-Inspector are kept and drilled at head-quarters as an armed reserve. For a long time this duty was performed by a company of the Chittagong Militia. Shortly before the Mutiny this company was disbanded; but in 1858 the Magistrate had enrolled a number of the old sepoys and others to form a guard 170 strong. The men were well paid getting Rs. 6 each, high wages in those days, but the correspondence does not show what became of them.

Village police.

That the Magistrates and police so entirely failed to maintain law and order in the early days of British administration may be ascribed in no small measure to the absence of a village watch or of any substitute for it. Mr. D. J. MacNeile, who made an enquiry into the village police of Bengal in 1866, failed to ascertain how or by whom the *chaukidārs* whom he found there were first appointed, but he was satisfied that there were none when Bhulua was separated from Tippera in 1821. It may be noted that in Sandwīp, and apparently near Noākhāli also, there were then living large numbers of ex-soldiers or descendants of ex-soldiers of the Mughal armies pensioned off with grants of land, but Mr. Walters found no *chaukīdārs* in 1819 and was so strongly impressed with the need of some such officers that he appointed *barkandāzes* at the principal *ghāts* as a provisional measure.

In 1840 the Collector reported that there were 1,760 village watchmen, who were appointed by the village headmen (*mātabars* or *mahalladārs*) and paid by collections from the villagers.

In 1876 the Bengal Chaukidāri Act was applied to the district, and the force organised as at present. Under this Act the villages are grouped together into "Unions," or *chaukidāri* villages, to each of which a managing committee of five persons, or *panchayet*, is appointed. The Magistrate fixes the number and pay of the *chaukidārs*, and the extent of each beat. The *panchayet* assess the villagers in proportion to their means, raising enough to meet the pay of the *chaukidārs*, and leave a small margin for contingencies. They have powers of distraint and are personally liable for the *chaukidārs'* pay if it falls into arrears. The tendency has been for the collecting member of the *panchayet* to get the whole power into his hands, and these collecting members have usurped almost all the dignity and functions of the former *mahalladārs* or village headmen. Of late years *dafadārs*

or literate watchmen have been appointed to assist the *panchayet* and serve as a connecting link between them and the police. They are also responsible for looking up bad characters at night. In 1908 there were 198 unions with 198 *dafadārs* and 1,894 *chaukidārs*, about 110 houses to each *chaukidār* according to the census. The *chaukidārs* get Rs. 5 a month, and the *dafadārs* Rs. 6, and their cost, including the 15 per cent. allowed for contingencies and the remuneration of the collecting *panchayet*, comes to Rs. 1,50,000. Most of the *chaukidārs* are recruited from the local Muhammadans.

Thirty-five *chaukidārs* were dismissed and 547 fined in 1908, and 134 got small rewards averaging Rs. 4. Under a system inaugurated in 1904 small additions to the monthly pay are provided from the *chaukidāri* reward fund for meritorious conduct; as more permanent marks of distinction brass chevrons are given.

Registration.

Under the Mughal rulers the local *kāzis* used to register deeds, but their registration was not always satisfactory, as will be seen from the following extract from Mr. Duncan's Report on Sandwīp.

The system of registration is described in the following terms:—

"There are two cazies or men who act under that quality in Sandwip, one for the 12 and another for the 4 anna division, receiving no allowance from Government and subsisting only by certain contingent fees and dues which they receive on attesting writings or performing other acts incident to their office in respect to marriages, etc. They are thence entirely dependent on the zemindar in whose part of the parganah they respectively reside, because his countenance and allowance is necessary to secure to them the regular receipt of their fees on sundry occasions."

By Regulation XXXVI of 1793 a registry of wills and deeds was established. The system was amended and amplified by various Acts, and finally by Act (III of 1877), which is (still) * in force. Under this Act 22 registration offices have been established in the district, and the number of deeds registered in 1908 was 73,716 of an aggregate value of Rs. 67,28,400. The deeds registered include over 15,000 deeds of sale or exchange, 23,000 mortgages, and 20,000 leases of which 5,200 were perpetual leases.

The Collector is also District Registrar and as such controls registration in the district subject to the direction of the Inspector-General. He is aided by a special Sub-Registrar who is in charge of registration at head-quarters, and also inspects rural offices. Since 1905 the Sub-Registrars have all been salaried and form a self-contained graded service; and the clerks and muharrirs on their establishment are now paid by Government. The receipts from registration in 1908 were Rs. 71,816 and the expenditure Rs. 52,458. The most important offices are Noākhāli, where a Joint Sub-Registrar is entertained to relieve the pressure, Lakhipur, Begamganj and Sandwīp.

* XVI of 1908 now.

Registration of Muhammadan marriages.

It appears that the Muhammadan Government levied a fee, known as *haldāri*, varying from Rs. 3 to Rs. 4-4 on all marriages, and in the case of a Muhammadan the ceremony had to be performed before the *kāzi* and *mufti*, who exacted further fees, and the expense of marriage under these conditions had proved a very serious encouragement to celibacy. The Regulations of 1772 abolished all these fees and prohibited *kāzis* from exacting any payment for officiating at a marriage except such as was offered voluntarily. Accordingly, though the appointments of *kāzis* in towns and *parganas* continued to be made by Government, these officers lost their position in the eyes of the people, and it became customary for marriages to be celebrated in the presence of any respectable Muhammadan, who chose to call himself *kāzi*. In 1864 the appointment of *kāzis* was discontinued, but the need of some system of registry of Muhammadan marriages became more and more apparent; the well-to-do indeed often executed marriage deeds, which were registered in the offices of the Registrars of Assurances, but the bulk of the people took no such precaution, and the courts found the greatest difficulty in dealing with questions of disputed marriage or legitimacy.

Bengal Act I of 1876 passed to remedy this evil provides for the appointment of Registrars of Muhammadan marriages, and Act XII of 1880 provides for the appointment of *kāzis*, though it imposes no obligation to have marriages performed by them. The Registrar is entitled to a fee of Re. 1 for registration, and to receive any gratuity that may be offered him. A *kāzi's* fees for officiating at any ceremony are regulated purely by agreement.

In 1907-08 there were 16 Registrars of Muhammadan marriages in Noākhāli, who registered upwards of 4,000 marriages and 1,000 divorces. All these Registrars have also been appointed to be *kāzis*, but there is no record of the number of ceremonies at which they have officiated in that capacity. The number of marriages registered is a very small fraction of the total, but in proportion to its size the system seems to have taken a greater hold on Noākhāli than on any other district.

Criminal justice.

The head of the judicial administration of the district is the District and Sessions Judge. As Sessions Judge he tries with the help of assessors all serious cases and hears appeals from all the first class Magistrates in the district. The District Magistrate tries but a few cases himself, but supervises the work of the other Magistrates, and hears appeals from those exercising second and third class powers.

In 1908 there were 9 subordinate stipendiary magistrates in the district besides a bench of Honorary Magistrates at Noākhāli and one Honorary Magistrate sitting singly.

Crime.

The crime in the district is comparatively light. As long ago as 1842 the Superintendent of Police (an Officer who

corresponded to the present Inspector-General) commented on the absence of serious crime and expressed the opinion that there must be a good deal which was not reported, but his inference apparently was not justified, and Noākhāli has continued to maintain an enviable reputation for peacefulness among the districts of Eastern Bengal. For the five years 1900—04 the average number of cases cognisable and non-cognisable reported was 4,880, rather less than in the preceding quinquennium. In 1908, 5,590 cases came before the courts, but of these only 3,130 were accepted as true, and only 966 persons were convicted. The true cases included 15 riots, 10 murders or homicides, 16 cases of grievous hurt, 38 of serious mischief, chiefly cattle poisoning, 223 house-breaking, and 159 thefts. Cattle poisoning, arson, and the making or passing of false coin are peculiarly rife in this district. They are all difficult to detect, and the reported figures probably do not show the extent to which they prevail.

Civil justice.

For the administration of civil justice the District Judge is assisted by a staff of one subordinate judge and 10 munsiffs. In 1908 the total number of original suits instituted was 23,118, of which 7,830 were money suits, 12,631 rent suits and 2,657 title suits. Civil litigation is not increasing much, the largest number of suits in any year since 1893 having been in 1899. The average value of the subject-matter of the suits for each of the three years ending with 1908 was Rs. 15,06,000.

Jail.

There is a small jail at Noākhāli for the accommodation of 95 prisoners, though it is capable at a pinch of holding a good many more, and the average daily population in 1908 was 177 persons of all classes. It is a very healthy jail, and in spite of the overcrowding in 1908, the average proportion of sick in hospital was less than 1 in 30, and only one death occurred. The prisoners cost in that year Rs. 97-9-0 each to maintain, and the profits of their labour were estimated only at Rs. 15-8-0 per head.

Finance.

The total revenue raised in the district in 1824 was Rs. 5,18,000, and in 1850-51 it had risen to Rs. 11,54,000, of which Rs. 3,62,000 was derived from the manufacture of salt. Owing partly to the abandonment of this manufacture and partly to poor collections it had dropped in 1870-71 to Rs. 8,84,000. Since then the Income Tax and the Road and Public Works Cess have been imposed; Land Revenue has grown, owing chiefly to the assessment of new alluvial formations in the estuary; Stamps and Registration yield an ever increasing revenue; and in 1908 the receipts under the principal heads, including the moiety of the Road and Public Works Cess credited to Government, was Rs. 14,70,000. This does not include the village assessment for the *chaukidārs*, nor the rates and taxes credited to local bodies, which would bring the total up to over Rs. 18,00,000.

Income tax.

In 1902-03 the income tax yielded Rs. 23,000 paid by 1,136 assessees. From that year the lowest limit of assessable income

was raised from Rs. 500 to Rs. 1,000 a year, but this measure while affording relief to a number of clerks and petty shokeepers, hardly affected the collections, which in 1908-9 amounted to Rs. 24,000 assessed on 600 persons.

Excise. The people of Noākhāli, both Hindus and Muhammadans, are extremely temperate, and the excise revenue is far less than in any other plains district in the province. In 1908-09 it was only Rs. 24,772 against Rs. 17,691 in 1892-93. The increase is due almost entirely to the greater consumption of opium and hemp drugs.

There is but little consumption of spirits, which are distilled from molasses on the outstill system, and bring in about Rs. 6,000 a year.

The consumption of opium has doubled in the last 18 years, and in 1908-09 the duty and license fees on it amounted together to Rs. 7,183. Ganja is the most popular drug, and yields a revenue of about Rs. 10,600 a year.

Stamps. The people of the district are highly litigious, ready to take the smallest dispute into court, and so distrustful of each other that the pettiest transactions are recorded in stamped agreements. Accordingly the revenue from stamps, both judicial and non-judicial, is expanding rapidly and amounted in 1908-09 to Rs. 5,40,398, of which Rs. 4,13,728 was derived from the sale of judicial stamps.

Cesses. Bengal Act IX of 1880 empowered the Collector to levy a road cess and a public works cess on the annual value of all immovable property in the district at a rate, not exceeding half an anna in the rupee for either cess, to be determined by the Road Cess Committee (now the District Board); the proceeds of the road cess to be paid to that Committee and that of the public works cess to be devoted to provincial public works and to subsidies to the district road fund.

These cesses are now levied at the maximum rate. The total demand in 1907-08 was Rs. 2,15,397 as against Rs. 1,37,278 in 1892-93. The rental of Noākhāli has increased enormously in the last thirty years, and large additions to the cess are obtained at every revaluation.

Arms Act. The Indian Arms Act, 1878, is in force, and under its provisions licenses for 703 fire-arms, of which 17 were breech-loaders, were in force at the end of 1908. Nearly a fourth of the licenses were given for protection against wild animals, but none of the larger carnivora were shot in the district during the year, and only one man and four head of cattle were killed by tigers and leopards. No persons residing in the district were exempted from the provisions of the Act either as great *zamīndārs* or as a special personal distinction.

Postal and Telegraph Statistics. In Noākhāli there are one head post office, 12 sub-offices, and 47 branch offices, and the number of letters received in 1909 was

over 2,040,000. There has been a great expansion of post office work of late years. In 1861-62 the total number of letters and parcels received was under 39,000, and as late as 1899-1900 there were only 35 post offices in all. The value of the money-orders issued has risen from Rs. 12,04,000 in 1899-1900 to Rs. 17,16,000 in 1908-09, and that of money-orders received from Rs. 7,20,000 to Rs. 14,81,000 in the same years.

There are only two telegraph offices besides those at the railway stations.

Surveys.

Periodical measurements were made during the Mughal period and large portions of the district were surveyed and settled in the early days of British rule. Sandwīp and the connected islands were surveyed by a Mr. Rawlins in 1787 and in 1833 by Captain Hodges. The lands of *pargana* Bhulua were measured about the year 1790 by Mr. Dandridge and many other estates were at one time or another in the *khās* possession of Government and measured by its officers. But these early surveys were made with only a pole, usually ten cubits in length, carried by two men, and were necessarily inaccurate. The results were not embodied in any map, and in course of time most of the old papers were lost or worm-eaten. The revenue survey made by a professional party in the years 1864-65 shows the boundaries of villages and estates and the main topographical features of the country, and as regards the lands along the Meghnā, the results were corrected in the Diara Survey of the year 1881-82. In 1893-95, 129½ square miles of the Chāklā Roshnābād estate lying in Noākhāli were surveyed and settled and field-to-field maps and detailed lists of tenancies prepared. Similar cadastral surveys were made also for some 255 square miles, chiefly Government estates, during the years 1895—1905 and for another 158 square miles since then.

CHAPTER XII.

LOCAL SELF-GOVERNMENT.

History.

The first experiment in Local Self-Government was the appointment in 1855 of a small committee to help the Magistrate in administering the Ferry Fund. Sir Frederick Halliday held that this gave no real assistance and only detracted from the Magistrate's responsibility* so the committee was abolished in 1857. Again in 1871 a Road Committee was established and was superseded from the 1st January 1875 by a Road Cess Committee which administered the proceeds of a cess levied at six pies in the rupee on the rental of the district.

Municipalities.

The only Municipality in the district is that of Sudharām, the head-quarters station. This was constituted in July 1876, and has 12 Municipal Commissioners, of whom one holds office ex-officio, and three are nominated by the Local Government. In 1907-8 the total income, including the contribution from Government of Rs. 500, was only Rs. 12,049, of which Rs. 5,190 were raised by taxes on the houses and lands at the rate of 7½ per cent. on their annual value, Rs. 4,800 by conservancy rates, and the balance was made up of taxes on animals, vehicles, profession, and trades, and of profits on pounds, rents, and miscellaneous items. The expenditure for the same year was Rs. 12,498, of which about 11 per cent. was on administration, and more than half on conservancy. To lighting and roads the Municipality devoted a tenth of its expenditure. It contributed Rs. 646 to hospitals, and Rs. 228 to education. The Commissioners take an interest in their work, and considering the small amount of money at their disposal, the Municipality is well run.

District Board.

The District Board of Noākhāli has 13 members, of whom four including the Chairman hold office ex-officio, three are nominated, and the rest elected by the Local Boards. The Board meet rather oftener than once a month, and the members are said to take a proper interest in their duties. Nearly all questions are considered in the first place by Standing Committees, on whom the bulk of the work falls.

Income.

In 1908-9 the opening balance of the Board was nearly Rs. 84,000, and its receipts during the year were over Rs. 2,57,000. This is a very substantial increase, for its average income for the ten years ending in 1901-02 was only Rs. 1,46,000. The increase is due in part to the larger collections of road cess, but chiefly to the much larger contributions received from provincial revenues. The contributions from provincial revenues amounted in

* Minute of the 8th April 1857.

1908-09 to Rs. 75,000 of which about Rs. 50,000 were for expenditure on education, Rs. 22,000 for the improvement of communications, Rs. 1,000 for the improvement of water-supply, and Rs. 2,000 for special works.

Expenditure.

The total expenditure in 1908-09 amounted to Rs. 2,40,000, out of which administration cost a little over Rs. 6,000. On education the Board spent Rs. 82,500, or 39 per cent. of its income; on communications it spent Rs. 79,000, of which about Rs. 46,000 were on original works, chiefly bridges, while it maintained five miles of metalled roads at an average cost of Rs. 280 per mile, and 390 miles of unmetalled road at an average cost of Rs. 166 per mile; this excludes 281 miles of village roads in charge of the Local Boards, on which only Rs. 48 per mile was expended.

There are 98 cattle pounds in the district under the charge of the Board. They are farmed out and yield a net profit of nearly Rs. 5,000 a year.

The ferries of the district are also in charge of the Board, and by an arrangement with the District Board of Chittagong half the profits of the Komira ferry are credited to Chittagong, and in return a half share of the sale proceeds of the Bāgkhāli, Sandwīp, and Lālganj ferries in Chittagong is paid to Noākhāli. The Board spent Rs. 19,600 on medical relief mostly in contributions to the dispensaries, which are managed by independent committees under its general control, and partly also in the direct relief of cholera by the deputation to the interior of medical officers to deal with outbreaks.

Local Boards.

There are only two Local Boards in the district, the *Sadr* and the Feni Boards, the former having 11 and the latter 9 members, all of whom are nominated, except the Chairman, who holds office ex-officio. These Boards have very restricted powers and little to do beyond maintaining the village roads and tanks.

Unions.

There are also four Union Committees at Feni, Lakhipur, Sandwīp and Hātia, each consisting of six members appointed by the Commissioner of the Division. They are entrusted with the maintenance of the village roads, the water-supply and the drainage, and are allowed to enjoy the income derived from the local funds, and may raise money by contributions or a local assessment. In 1908-09 their total income amounted to Rs. 2,640, of which Rs. 1,829 was contributed by the District Board. It is said that they worked fairly well, but in the previous year the Hātia Committee failed to take a proper interest in its duties, and had to be reconstituted.

CHAPTER XIII.

EDUCATION.

History.

In the year 1870-71 there were 26 Government and aided schools, in 9 of which English was taught, and the number of pupils was under 600. Sir George Campbell's educational reforms gave a great stimulus to the opening of schools, and in the year 1874-75 there were 187 Government and aided schools attended by upwards of 6,000 boys. In 1895-96 the number of schools attained its maximum of 2,775, and the returns of attendance showed nearly 58,000 pupils. At this time a change in the policy led to the disappearance of a good many bogus *pāthshālās* and in 1897-98 the number of schools was only 1,330 with less than 34,000 pupils. In 1908-09 the number of schools had risen to 1,518 with over 62,500 pupils on the rolls. Of these schools, 61 were secondary, 1,257 primary, 20 were special schools, and 180, of which 44 were advanced and the rest elementary, did not comply with any recognised standard.

Expenditure.

The expenditure on public instruction has risen steadily. In 1901-02 it was Rs. 1,12,000. In 1908-09 it was over Rs. 2,47,000. Of this sum Rs. 49,000 was contributed from provincial revenues, Rs. 77,000 from local funds, Rs. 1,00,000 from fees, and the balance from private sources. Classified otherwise, Rs. 64,000 were spent on secondary schools, Rs. 94,000 on primary schools, Rs. 8,000 on special schools, Rs. 59,000 on buildings and furniture, Rs. 17,000 on inspection, Rs. 2,500 on scholarships, and the balance chiefly on hostel charges.

Secondary education.

There are five High English Schools, of which one is maintained and three aided by Government, containing altogether over 1,300 pupils. There are also 55 English and Vernacular Middle Schools with some 5,700 pupils; of these 4 are managed by local authorities, and all the rest, except six, are aided.*

The cost of education comes to nearly Rs. 20 per pupil in the High Schools, and to rather over Rs. 6-4-0 in the Middle Schools, and the amount recovered from fees comes to Rs. 14 a head in the High Schools, and between Rs. 3-4-0 and Rs. 3-12-0 a head in the others.

Primary education.

There are 133 Upper Primary Schools with 8,500 pupils, and 1,124 Lower Primary Schools with 41,000 pupils, among which there are 307 Girls' Schools with 7,500 pupils. This comes to very nearly one primary school to every square mile or to every two villages.

The cost of education in the Upper Primary Schools comes to rather less than Rs. 3 per pupil, and the amount recovered

* Where no year is specified the figures are for 1908-09.

from fees to about Rs. 1-11-0 per pupil. In the lower primary standard boys cost a little under Rs. 2 each and two-thirds of this amount is recovered from fees; girls cost less than a rupee a head, but pay practically no fees.

Madrasas.

There are four aided *Madrasas* with some 500 pupils, but besides these there are 42 advanced schools with nearly 1,500 pupils, teaching Arabic or Persian according to their own standards, and 132 Elementary Schools in which 3,000 boys are taught the *Korān*. There are 14 Sanskrit *Tols*, besides two other schools in which Sanskrit is taught, but the total number of pupils is only 250.

Educational standard.

In 1881 about one male out of every eleven, and less than one woman in every 2,000 could read and write. In 1901-02 among the male population 21½ per cent. of the Hindus and 7 per cent. of the Muhammadans could read and write, while of women, one in every 110 Hindus and one in every 500 Muhammadans, were literate. The number of persons who could read and write English in 1901 was 2,270.

It is difficult to say whether there has really been much advance in education in the last 15 years. The number of schools shown in 1895-96 was 2,775 with nearly 58,000 pupils on the rolls. In 1898-99 there were only 33,500, and in 1907-08 there were 60,000 amounting according to the returns of the of the educational department to 35 per cent. of the population of the school-going age. The following year added about 2,500 to the number of students, but on the other hand the school-going population appears to have been calculated on the basis of the census of 1901, making no allowance for the rapid growth of population since then. It would be safe to say that the number of children of the school-going age must have increased by 10 per cent., and calculated on this basis the proportion of children at school in 1908-09 to those of school-going age is about 33 per cent. Of boys alone the number in 1908-09 was about 52,000 equivalent to 55 per cent. of those school-going age.

Female education

In 1899-1900 there were 63 girls' schools in the district with 1,138 pupils. In 1908-09 there were one middle vernacular and 310 primary and elementary schools with upwards of 7,500 pupils, and another 3,000 were reading in boys' schools, making the total about 12 per cent. of the girls of school-going age. Two Model Girls' Schools have been established and 18 female teachers appointed.

The popular prejudice against the education of women is dying out fast, and the marriageable age of a girl in the respectable classes of Hindu society has risen perceptibly.

Management and inspection.

The management of primary and middle schools is entrusted to the District Board, and in towns to the Municipal Commissioners. High Schools are managed by School Committees subject to the control of the Educational Department. Such Committees

exist also for Middle and occasionally for Upper Primary Schools, but in regard to these are rarely of much assistance. Unaided schools are of course free from Government control, except in so far as they have to conform with the orders of the University. Until the current year the Subordinate Inspecting Agency was under the local authorities, but has now been placed under the Educational Department. The sanctioned staff for Noākhāli consists of 3 Deputy Inspectors, 11 Sub-Inspectors, and 2 Assistant Sub-Inspectors, all under the orders of the Inspector of Schools for the Chittagong Division. The whole of this staff has not been appointed.

CHAPTER XIV.

GAZETTEER.

Ambarabad or Omarabad.—A *pargana* in the west of the district, lying west and north of Bhulua with an area of 124·4 square miles, containing 960 permanently settled estates with a total revenue of Rs. 81,633. It is said to have been carved out of the old *rāj* of Bhulua in the beginning of the eighteenth century when it was still an uninhabited waste. The story runs that a Persian *pīr* by name Ambar (or Omar) Shāh came to the district and lived there in his boat working miracles and making multitudes of converts by whom the wastes were gradually reclaimed. He gave his name to the *pargana*, and it was at his instance that the Emperor Muhammad Shāh settled it with two brothers of Dehli, Amānullah and Sanāullah Khān at the very low revenue of Rs. 289. It appears in the accounts of 1728 as Omarābād Noābād Bhulua at that revenue.

Gambling and extravagance soon brought the proprietors into difficulties and they crippled their resources further by giving away most of the *pargana* in *tāluks*. Down to 1791 they paid a revenue of Rs. 50,000, and the Board then ordered settlement to be made with the *tālukdārs*. The demand was fixed at Rs. 1,06,437 but the *tālukdārs* refused to accept this and the estate was held *khās* for some time. It was not until 1795 that the Board sanctioned the settlement of the *pargana* for a revenue of Rs. 95,631.

The *pargana* was divided at first into 1,406 estates of which 41 were in the possession of Government and 5 were unsettled. In the first quinquennial register these five became 188, and 380 others were bought in at sales for arrears of revenue; so that at the time of the formation of the district of Noākhāli Government was in possession of 605 estates with a nominal revenue of Rs. 41,683. Of these, however, 90 could not be identified and others had lapsed into jungle, and eventually they were all consolidated under two *tauzi* numbers and farmed out for Rs. 27,179. The farming settlements continued for many years, until in 1869 the property was settled with the late farmer's widow subject to a permanent revenue of Rs. 30,000 and a premium of Rs. 80,000. The estate is now in the possession of Gobinda Chandra Singh and others of Murshidabad.*

Babupur.—*Pargana* in Begamganj and Feni *thānās*, area 37·33 square miles, 35 estates, land revenue Rs. 14,952. Said to have been a part of Bhulua granted to Bābu Khān, a Brāhman

* Collector's letter dated the 3rd February 1863.

from Hindustān, whose brothers' names survive in their houses Damad Khān bāti and Ārab Khān bāti. After Bābu Khān's death the *pargana* passed into the possession of a branch of the Sūr family, and in 1728 stood in the name of Uday Nārāyan Chaudhuri with a revenue of Rs. 350. In 1765 the revenue is shown as Rs. 12,984.

A feud among the owners, caused by the love affairs of one Rāj Chandra who wanted to marry a dancing girl, led to a great fight still celebrated in song as the 'Chaudhurir Larāi.' The estate was then divided and Government acquired successively at sales for arrears of revenue a one anna and a one anna eleven ganda share and settled them with other persons, while the greater part of the residue was bought by one Rādhākrishna Mazumdār, *diwān* of a former proprietor. His descendants were profligate and extravagant, and once more the estate came under the hammer. The six anna share went to the *zamīndārs* of Bhulua, and the rest to various persons.

A two anna share remained in the family down to 1865 when it was sold to satisfy the proprietor's debts and bought by Muhammad Kābil Miā for Rs. 10,920.

Bhulua.—The largest *pargana* in the district; area 245·5 square miles, divided into 185 estates at a total land revenue of Rs. 1,23,929. It represents the remnant of the dominions of the Sūr Rājās and in the revenue roll of 1728 A.D. stood in the name of Kirti Nārāyan with a revenue of Rs. 41,161; in 1789 A.D. the revenue was Rs. 99,469. In 1785 a four anna share was purchased by Ganga Gobinda Singh of Kāndi in the district of Murshidābād, the *Diwān* of Lord Hastings and founder of the Paikpārā family. He applied for partition, and Mr. Dandridge and afterwards a Mr. Meyer were deputed to effect it, but the parties objected to the award and in 1810 we find the twelve anna proprietors praying for the appointment of a common manager.* In 1833 the estate was brought to sale for arrears of revenue and bought by Dwarka Nāth Tagore, who sold it for about three lakhs of rupees to Rāni Katyāyani of the Paikpārā family, the ancestress of the present proprietors. The estate is now in the hands of the Administrator-General and is managed by a local Sub-Manager stationed at Noākhāli. Most of the property is let out in *pātni*.

Bhulua village a few miles west of Noākhāli on the Lakhipur road. Site of the Muhammadan fort established in the seventeenth century, and head-quarters of the district in the eighteenth

* *Vide* Collector's letters dated the 14th May 1790 and 19th March 1807. The purchaser is described as Ganga Nārāyan Chaudhri, and I am told that the purchase was made *benāmi* in this name. According to the Noākhāli Itihāsh the four anna share first purchased by Ganga Gobinda Singh was the part known as the Ashtahāzāri, which in the time of Rāni Shashimukhi, had passed out of the hands of the Sūr family and had been settled with her *diwān* Nara Nārāyan Rai.

century. It is not clear when it was abandoned, but in 1821 the Joint Magistrate was posted to Noākhāli, which seems to have been the head-quarters ever since.

Dandra.—*Pargana*, area 39·45 square miles. It is closely associated with Allahābād, area 8·17 square miles, and the two are divided into 36 estates with a land revenue of Rs. 22,340. These two formed the lands granted to a Muhammadan General for the protection of the frontier, and in 1728 stood in the name of Muhammad Arifat Chaudhuri with a revenue of Rs. 7,486. When it came under the Collector of Tippera in 1790 A.D. the *zamīndārs* were a most turbulent lot, and one of them before long was lodged in jail on charges of rape and murder, while the property was administered by the Collector. There were disputes as to the succession, and half was awarded to Muhammad Wāsik and Muhammad Amjad and the other half to Ilyās Khān. The main property was divided into five estates of Dāndrā and two in Allahābād. Three of the former, making up 8 annas 18 *gandas* of the *pargana*, were in possession of Government in 1861, a four anna share belonged to Muhammad Arshud and three annas odd to Afrunnissa. In 1864 Government sold its shares, four annas going to the Rājā of Hill Tippera and three annas to Faizunnissa Chaudhurani and others.

The other four anna share was bought by Manohar Ali Chaudhuri, and has since been sold again for arrears of revenue and bought by the Dālāl Bāzār *zamīndārs*. Chandra Nāth Chaudhuri of Senerkhil—*thānā* Feni—was the owner of a share of three annas odd. He is dead and his three sons and wife are now the joint proprietors.

Feni.—Sub-division in the east of the district; area 343 square miles; population 318,837. The sub-division was formed in 1876 and included at first *thānās* Feni, Chhāgalnāiya, and Mirkāsarai, but this last was retransferred in 1878 to Chittagong and part of Bāmni *thānā* was then made over to the sub-division. The central portion of the sub-division is low alluvial plain, similar to the rest of the district; the eastern portion, which abuts on Hill Tippera, is higher and sometimes undulating, with occasional mounds, *dipahs*, rising above the general level, and is liable to be flooded by the overflow of the hill streams. The Assam-Bengal Railway runs through the heart of the sub-division which is well supplied with roads and water communication. This sub-division is watered and drained by the big and little Feni rivers, the Muhuri and its tributaries the Silonia and Gotia, and by several sluggish canals or *khāls*.

The whole of *thānā* Chhāgalnāiya forms part of Chakla Roshnābād, an estate under the collectorate of Tippera belonging to His Highness the Rājā of Hill Tippera. Most of the neighbourhood of Feni station lies in *pargans* Amirābād and

Bedarābād, known as the Courjon estate but now the property of the Laws of Calcutta.

Feni.—Head-quarters of the sub-division of that name. There is no village of Feni, but in 1876 the head-quarters were established at Khyārā some two miles from the Feni river, which gave its name to the station. The site was found unsuitable and the town is now situated in *mauzas* Barāhipur, Shaivadebpur, Dādpur, Rampur, and Chāripur. It is on the Assam-Bengal Railway, 56 miles from the Chittagong terminus, the town is growing fast, and its roads and sanitation and that of the adjacent rural areas are managed by a Union Committee under the control of the Local Board. The principal buildings stand round the Rājāji's tank excavated by the District Board in 1890.

Jagdia.—*Pargana* between Bhulua and the Feni river. Area 67·37 square miles, 5 estates, land revenue Rs. 28,705. It was given as a *jāgīr*, valued in 1722 A.D. at Rs. 16,984, to Burā Khān, a Hindu appointed in the time of the Emperor Aurangzeb to guard the frontier. He is said to have given it to a Brāhman child, and in the decennial settlement it was divided into three estates, Brāhman, Dās and Kabirāj. There are now a large number of small proprietors who are represented by a common manager.

Lakhipur.—Site of a *thānā* of that name and of a sub-registry office, post office, and inspection bungalow. Connected by road with Sudharām (23 miles), Begamganj (19 miles), and Rāipur (10 miles). There was a cloth factory here established in 1756 and its ruins, known as Jackson's *kuti*, are still to be seen. It is an important mart, specially famous for its molasses, and has a population of over 5,000 souls. Its local affairs are managed by a Union under the *Sadr* Local Board.

Raipur.—At the mouth of the Dākātiā in the extreme north-east of the district on the Lakhipur-Chāndpur road. The most important mart in the district, with a large export of betel-nut, coco-nut, oranges, limes, and plantains. The office of the joint sub-registrar of Lakhipur is here, and there is an inspection bungalow.

Sandwip.—A large island in the Bay of Bengal separated from the mainland of Noākhāli by the Bāmni river. It was inhabited at a comparatively early date, and the Venetian traveller Cesare Federico who saw it in the year 1569 described it as one of the most fertile places in the world densely populated and well cultivated. It was then in the possession of the Muhammadans, and in the beginning of the seventeenth century passed into the hands of Portuguese adventurers. In 1662 it was under Mughal administration and formed with the adjoining islands of Hātia, Bāmni, and Shāgīrd-dihi, a single *pargana* divided into three estates or *tarafs*, each of which had lands in all the islands and a share of common lands. There were disturbances in the island in 1767 which were

quelled by troops, the owner of a 4 annas 1 ganda 3 courie share, Abu Tarāp, being killed in the fighting and his interests confiscated and made over to one Gokul Ghoshāl, Diwān of the Nawāb and real Ahdadār of the islands, whose machinations and oppressions led to Mr. Duncan being deputed to hold an enquiry in 1778. This share was thereafter known as *tarāf* Bhawāni Charan, after a servant of Gokul Ghoshāl in whose name it was registered.* In 1786 this *tarāf* paid revenue in Bhulua, and the others in Chittagong. At the time of the permanent settlement a number of petty estates were formed by the separation of *tāluks* or the resumption of grants. Between 1797 and 1821 two *tarāfs*, 5 annas 0 ganda 2 couries and 2 annas 15 gandas were sold for arrears of revenue and bought by Prān Krishta Biswās, whose estate was in turn brought to sale on the 1st July 1824 and bought by Government. The other interests were sold up soon after, and by 1830 all the original estates of the *pargana* were in the possession of Government. By an order dated the 29th June 1830 Government cancelled the sale of *taraf* Bhawāni Charan and directed its return to the owners in satisfaction of a decree they had obtained; but there was delay in giving effect to the order and the lands were measured along with the rest of the estate. In 1841 they were made over to a receiver of the High Court, and the rest were settled for thirty years, those in Hātia, Sandwīp, and Bāmni being dealt with separately by three different officers. In these settlements new alluvial formations were included and several of the small petty estates consisting of *khārija tāluks* or resumed lands were amalgamated.

In 1890 the Government estates in Sandwīp, Bāmni, and Hātia were sold for Rs. 1,95,000, half being purchased by Mr. Courjon and half by Mr. Delauney and Shib Dulāl Tewāri jointly, the revenue for the three estates being fixed in perpetuity at Rs. 38,120. The present proprietors of these estates are the representatives of the purchasers, and those of Bhawāni Charan's estate are Mrs. Delauney and the heirs of Shib Dulāl Tewāri. It is worthy of note that the purchasers of the Government estates are not allowed to have any right to new accretions †.

Sudharam.—Sudharām on the west bank of the Noākhāli *khāl* about two miles from the sea is the head-quarters of the district. It is said that the Muhammadans had an outpost here in about the year 1620, but in Rennell's time, 1787, it was not important enough to be shown in his atlas. In 1821 it was chosen as the head-quarters of the Joint Magistrate appointed to the charge of the

* The twelve anna estate referred to in the old correspondence seems to have been made up of this share and of others of which Gokul Ghoshāl had possessed himself wrongly and which on Mr. Duncan's recommendation were restored to their former owners.

† This account is based on Mr. H. G. Cook's report of the 20th April 1882; and on the report of the settlement of Bāmni, 1903. Mr. Dampier's report of 1837 gives the fullest detail.

district of Bhulua. It was formerly known as Noākhāli, and took its present name from one Sudhārām Mazumdār, a wealthy merchant and benefactor, who excavated the large tank known by his name.

In 1876 it was constituted a Municipality, but the municipal revenue is only Rs. 12,000, and the population in 1901 was 6,520. It is really nothing but a rural bāzār with a few Government offices and residential buildings. It was completely wrecked by the cyclone of 1893, and the Government offices erected since then are fine substantial buildings. There is a neat little Town Hall with a stage, billiard room, and library attached to it, and a good Circuit House has been built lately. The drinking water is supplied from Sudharām's tank, a fine one but spoilt by the growth of weeds. The town is connected by railway with Lāksām, and steamers run from it to the islands and to Barisāl.

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